

# The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

## Andy Burnham takes office and rewires the state

**B**ritain changed Prime Minister with its elected House on holiday. The Commons rose on Thursday 16 July for a recess that runs to 31 August; Sir Keir Starmer had taken his last Prime Minister's Questions the day before, announced as such from the Chair. On Monday 20 July Andy Burnham became Prime Minister. On Tuesday 21 July a written statement, laid in the House

of Lords and made on the Prime Minister's behalf, told Parliament that "Today, we are fundamentally rewiring the state, changing the geography of government" — abolishing the Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, creating an Office for the Prime Minister and the Cabinet with a "No.10 North" inside it, and renaming the business department. The only question put

on it was a Private Notice Question in the Lords. Behind it sat two crowded sitting days: the first use of the new state-threats designation power against the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, a nationalisation of British Steel carried out outside working hours, which drew a ministerial apology, and 38 councils announced to replace 134.

**THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST**

**Trade Unions (Permissible Means of Voting) and Employment Rights (Unfair Dismissal) (Amendment) Order**

330

Carried by 221 on 15 July

109

**Code of Practice on Electronic and Workplace Ballots for Statutory Trade Union Ballots**

330

Carried by 221 on 15 July

109

### THE WEEK IN BRIEF

**Prime Minister's Questions, 15 July.** Sir Keir Starmer took his last session as Prime Minister. The Speaker told the House from the Chair that it was the final Prime Minister's Questions with him in office. Kemi Badenoch turned to what she called this Prime Minister's final questions and paid her own tribute to Ann Widdecombe. There has been no session since, because the Commons rose the next day.

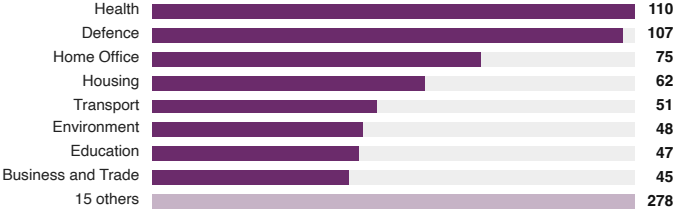
**National security designations, 15 July.** The Commons approved regulations designating the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, the Islamic Movement of Companions of the Right and the GRU Volunteer Corps. Supporting or taking material benefit from a designated body now carries up to fourteen years in prison. Dame Angela Eagle told the House this was the first use of the new power. There was no division.

**British Steel, 15 and 16 July.** The Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Act received Royal Assent on 15 July. The Government used it overnight to take British Steel into public ownership. The regulations were not laid before Parliament before they came into force. Answering an urgent question the next morning, the business minister Blair McDougall offered regret and apologies for that, and said the transfer had been done outside of working hours.

**Local government reorganisation, 16 July.** Steve Reed announced decisions for the remaining two-tier areas of England. Across those areas 38 councils will replace 134. He told the House there would be nearly 3,000 fewer councillors, and that councils themselves project net savings of about £1 billion by 2032-33. Elections to the new councils are due in May 2027.

**Machinery of Government Changes, 21 July.** A written statement laid in the House of Lords set out the new shape of government. A Private Notice Question from Lord Clement-Jones followed the same afternoon. Baroness Anderson of Stoke-on-Trent confirmed that UK Research and Innovation and the sovereign artificial intelligence fund move to the renamed business department, and that the £9.22 billion research budget for 2026-27 continues. Asked about her own position she said she could not talk about appointments still being made.

### WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT



### THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

8 Basildon Council: Best Value · 7 Body Searches · 7 Defence: Space Technology · 7 Gaza: Development Aid · 6 Special Educational Needs · 5 Educational Institutions: Industrial Disputes · 5 Prisoners' Release · 5 Schools: Temperature · 4 Civil Service: Gender Recognition · 4 Council Tax: Valuation

### THE FEATURE

#### The Basildon file

James McMurdock, the Independent Member of Parliament for South Basildon and East Thurrock, tabled eighteen written questions in two days on the Best Value Notice issued to Basildon Borough Council on 15 July. The Housing Secretary said his concerns there related to serious cultural and governance

issues, and commissioned an independent review to report by the end of October 2026. McMurdock asked what evidence led Ministers to issue the notice, who was consulted, which Ministers and officials decided, what the review will cost and whether its findings will be published in full.

### A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK'S QUESTIONS

**RAF Barnham** · Rupert Lowe, Restore Britain

*To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what estimate has been made of the total cost of returning MoD Barnham to its previous condition following the conclusion of its use as asylum accommodation; and which department will cover that cost.*

**THE ANSWER** The Government is considering whether to sue MoD Barnham for asylum accommodation. No final decision has been taken.

### THE RECORD

Every figure checked against the official Parliament record. Compiled from the Official Report, the written question record and the division lists, and rendered to one sheet for the week.